

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GEORGIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Georgia, communities discover that a place they depend on — a river gorge, a mountain valley, a forest, a stretch of Black Sea coast, a village and its farmland — has been handed to something destructive. A large hydropower cascade on a river. A mine. A quarry. A resort or a road cut through protected land. A transmission line. A landfill. The first sign is often the survey crews, the drilling and blasting, the news that state land has been transferred to a company, or a permit granted for "preparatory works" before anyone in the valley was properly consulted.

This guide is a practical manual for those communities. It explains how the approval system for large projects works in Georgia, where the genuine openings are, what documentation matters, how to organise, and how to use the levers that have here delivered one of the region's most remarkable community victories. It does not promise that any project can be stopped. It offers a clear-eyed method that gives you the best possible chance.

Georgia holds two truths at once, and you must carry both. The first is genuinely inspiring. **In Georgia, ordinary people have stopped a major project through sheer, sustained mobilisation.** When the Namakhvani hydropower cascade — a 424-megawatt scheme that would have transformed the Rioni Valley in western Georgia — began preparatory works, a handful of local residents began a protest that grew into a national movement. The "Guardians of Rioni" camped in tents for months, drew tens of thousands to the streets of Kutaisi and Tbilisi, and refused to leave. In 2021, the project was suspended and the foreign developer withdrew. A dam cascade the government called essential to the country's energy independence was stopped — not by a court, but by a valley that would not yield.

The second truth is sobering, and it is specific to Georgia's situation. **Winning can carry a heavy price, and the ground beneath civil society has been shifting.** After the developer withdrew, it took Georgia to international arbitration and won, leaving the state facing a compensation award of hundreds of millions of dollars — a warning about the investor-state agreements that many large projects rest on. And the very movement that saved the Rioni has since been smeared by the ruling party, which pushed a "foreign agents" law and cast Western-funded NGOs and protesters as foreign or hostile actors. Georgia shows both what people power can win and how the space to exercise it can narrow.

Georgia is a hybrid democracy: it has elections, a free-ish press, courts, an Environmental Assessment Code aligned with European standards, and it is a party to the Aarhus Convention — but its institutions are weaker and less reliable than those of a full democracy, its permitting has at times been a formality following decisions already made, and its civic space has come under real pressure. Understanding both the openings and the limits is the most important thing this

guide can give you.

The Strategic Framework

The core idea is simple: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions and dependencies, and a chain can be broken at its weakest link.** A project needs its environmental permit; it needs a complete and lawful environmental-impact assessment; it needs its land and construction permits; it needs the acquiescence of a community that in the Rioni Valley refused to give it; and it needs to avoid the scrutiny of the courts, the Public Defender, the Aarhus mechanisms, the press, and — decisively in Georgia — a mobilised public. Each is a potential point of leverage.

Your task is to find the link you can reach. Sometimes it is the environmental permit and a defective or incomplete EIA — the very flaw that undermined the Namakhvani permits. Sometimes it is the administrative court. Sometimes it is the Aarhus rights to information and participation. Sometimes it is the Public Defender. And often — more than almost anywhere in this guide — it is the sustained, disciplined, locally-rooted weight of a community that will not go home.

Critical Caveat: Which Situation Are You In?

Throughout this guide you will find honest assessments, because a guide that promised any project can be stopped by the right petition would be lying.

Where a project depends on an environmental permit you can challenge, and — above all — where a community can mobilise and sustain itself, Georgia's levers are real, and people power has won outright — the Rioni Valley is the proof.

Where the state has already decided, transferred the land, and signed a confidential deal, and where civic space is under pressure, the institutional levers are weaker — the permit may be a formality and the courts uncertain. There, mobilisation, documentation, the Aarhus mechanisms, and international attention matter most, and you must weigh the risks clearly.

Knowing which situation you are in is among the most important judgments you will make, and much of this guide is designed to help you judge accurately.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before acting, and read the organising, legal, and tilted-system sections with care, because in Georgia mass mobilisation is often the decisive lever, the institutions are uneven, and the civic climate shapes everything. Two principles run throughout. First, **build the public**: because Georgia's institutions are weaker than a full democracy's, a broad, sustained, locally-rooted movement is frequently what wins, as it did in the Rioni. Second, **combine the strands**: documentation, the permit challenge, the Aarhus mechanisms, the courts, the Public Defender, media, and international allies work far better together, and reinforce the public pressure that is your strongest card.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pressure a chain you cannot see. This section maps the bodies that decide, the journey a project takes, the rules that matter, the incentives that drive decisions, and the overseers who can hold the system to account.

The Bodies That Decide

The Ministry of Environmental Protection and Agriculture. This ministry runs the environmental-assessment procedure and issues the **environmental permit** — the central approval a large project needs. It conducts the review of the environmental-impact assessment (EIA), the scoping, and the public consultation. This is your first and most important formal arena, because the permit is the document the project rests on, and — as the Namakhvani case showed — it can be granted on an incomplete or defective assessment, which makes it challengeable.

The administrative courts. Georgia's courts — the city courts' administrative chambers, the Court of Appeals, and the Supreme Court — hear challenges to environmental and construction permits. Civil-society organisations sued to annul the Namakhvani permit on exactly the ground that it was issued without the required studies. The courts are a real arena, though their independence is contested and outcomes are less certain than in a full democracy.

The government and its economic bodies. Large "strategic" projects are often driven by the government, the Ministry of Economy, or state-linked entities such as the Georgian Energy Development Fund, which have at times selected

developers and negotiated confidential agreements. Understanding that the government may have already decided — and transferred the land — before the permit is issued is essential to reading your situation.

Local self-government. Municipalities handle local permits and land matters and can be allies or obstacles; the affected community's own municipality is a natural focus.

The Public Defender (Ombudsman). Georgia's Public Defender is an independent oversight body that investigates rights violations and has intervened in environmental conflicts — during the Rioni protests, the Public Defender challenged the police blockade of the valley as disproportionate. It is a real, if non-binding, lever.

The Aarhus mechanisms. Georgia is a party to the Aarhus Convention, which guarantees access to environmental information, public participation, and access to justice — and whose Compliance Committee can be petitioned where those rights are denied.

Parliament and the political arena. Parliament and the political parties shape the law and the climate, and a project can become a national political issue, as Namakhvani did.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Stage 1 — Selection and land. A "strategic" project is often decided early: a developer selected, state land transferred, an agreement — sometimes confidential — signed. In the Namakhvani case, hundreds of hectares were transferred before the permits, which turned the later procedure into a formality. Recognising this stage is crucial, because by the time the permit is issued the real decision may already have been made.

Stage 2 — Environmental assessment and permit. The EIA, the scoping, and the public consultation lead to the environmental permit. This is the decisive formal stage — and the stage whose defects you challenge.

Stage 3 — Construction permit and works. Construction and other permits follow, then the works — drilling, blasting, riverbed alteration — often beginning with "preparatory" activities that cause harm before the full permit is settled.

Stage 4 — Operation and harm. Flooding of a valley, loss of a river, displacement, and their effects on people and land follow — the toll that documentation must capture.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Matter

You need not be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that give your case its force:

- **The Environmental Assessment Code**, aligned with European standards, which requires an EIA, scoping, and genuine public participation, and sets the grounds on which a permit issued without them is unlawful.
- **The Aarhus Convention**, guaranteeing access to information, participation, and justice — a binding international lever.
- **Georgian administrative law**, governing how permits are issued and challenged, and the transparency of the process.
- **The Constitution's protections** of a healthy environment, property, and assembly.

The pattern to hold in mind: on paper Georgia's environmental law is modern and European-aligned; in practice, permits have been granted on incomplete assessments after decisions were already made. **That gap between the law and the practice is often your strongest legal ground** — and the public pressure is often what forces it to matter.

Follow the Money — Why Projects Proceed

Understand the incentives and you understand the pressure. The government wants investment and "energy independence"; state-linked funds and ministries champion strategic projects; foreign investors want returns, often secured by confidential agreements and state guarantees — including obligations for the state to buy the output. The environmental and social cost falls on communities and on Georgia's rivers, valleys, and forests. That is why the public, the courts, and the Aarhus mechanisms matter — and why the confidential, investor-favouring terms of these deals are themselves a vulnerability you can expose.

The Overseers — Who Can Hold the System to Account

- **The administrative courts**, which can annul an unlawful permit.
- **The Public Defender**, who investigates rights violations and disproportionate policing.
- **The Aarhus Convention Compliance Committee**, for denials of information, participation, or justice.

- **Parliament and the political opposition**, where a project becomes a national issue.
- **A free-ish press and a strong environmental civil society** — Green Alternative, the Social Justice Center, CENN, the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, Caucasian House, and international partners such as CEE Bankwatch.
- **The mobilised public**, which in the Rioni Valley proved the most powerful overseer of all.

These are the overseers your strategy must reach. Much of the rest of this guide is about building a case strong enough to move them — and, above all, a public strong enough to prevail.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns from how Georgian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variable is not fully in the table: **whether a community can mobilise and sustain itself, and how far the state has already committed to the project**. For a project where a broad public can be built, Georgia's most powerful lever — mass mobilisation — has won outright; where the state has decided, transferred the land, and the courts are uncertain, discount the institutional figures and lean hardest on the public, the Aarhus mechanisms, and international attention.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Public participation in the EIA	15-35%	during review	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Permit / EIA challenge (court)	20-40%	12-36 months	moderate	Permit annulled; process redone; delay
Aarhus mechanisms (info, participation, justice)	20-40%	6-36 months	low	Rights enforced; process reopened; pressure
Public Defender referral	15-35%	3-18 months	low	Findings; scrutiny; protection of protesters
Mass, sustained public mobilisation	35-60%	6-36 months	low	Project suspended, withdrawn, or shelved
International attention / investor pressure	20-45%	6-36 months	low	Financier or investor retreat; leverage
All steps combined (mobilisable community)	45-65%	12-36 months	low-moderate	Stopped, suspended, or delayed
All steps combined (state-decided, civic space tight)	20-40%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed, conditioned; sometimes stopped

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one, and Georgia's real strength is unusual — **a proven capacity for mass, locally-rooted mobilisation** that has stopped a major project, reinforced by a modern **Environmental Assessment Code**, the **Aarhus Convention**, an independent **Public Defender**, and a determined **environmental civil society**. Its constraints are **weaker, less reliable courts, permitting that can be a formality after decisions are already made, civic space under pressure**, and — distinctively — the **investor-state arbitration risk** that can make stopping a foreign-backed project costly for the state.

A note on cost: participating, documenting, and organising are inexpensive. The expenditure that changes outcomes is a lawyer experienced in environmental and administrative law — available through Georgia's environmental legal groups (the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, the Social Justice Center, Green Alternative) — and the sustained effort of a committed community.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (stopped, suspended, or delayed)

MOBILISABLE COMMUNITY -- broad public, legal support, Aarhus + courts engaged:

All steps combined:	45-65%
Mass mobilisation:	35-60%
Aarhus / court challenge:	20-40%
International pressure:	20-45%
Single step:	5-35%

STATE-DECIDED PROJECT -- land transferred, deal signed, civic space tight:

All steps combined:	20-40%
Public + international:	the strongest combination
Delay / exposure:	more achievable than an outright stop
Single step:	5-25%

How to read this honestly. The lever that most changes outcomes in Georgia is **the public** — reinforced by documentation, the permit challenge, the Aarhus mechanisms, and international attention. Rioni shows the ceiling: a valley that would not yield, backed by a national movement, stopped a dam the government called essential. The floor is set by the state's habit of deciding early and transferring land before the permit, by courts of uncertain independence, and by a civic space that has narrowed since 2021. Most Georgian fights sit between them, and the honest lesson is that mobilisation is your strongest card, the institutional levers are real but uneven, and winning may carry costs the movement must anticipate.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Mass, sustained, locally-rooted mobilisation** — the lever that stopped Namakhvani and Georgia's single strongest card.
2. **The environmental permit and the EIA** — the challenge to a permit granted on an incomplete or unlawful assessment, in court and through the Aarhus mechanisms.
3. **Documentation** — the record that every court, overseer, and journalist acts on, and that exposes the confidential, investor-favouring terms.
4. **The Aarhus mechanisms and the Public Defender** — the rights-based levers that reopen a process and protect a movement.
5. **International attention and media** — the scrutiny that reaches investors, financiers, and European partners.

What Georgian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **People power can win** — the Rioni Valley movement suspended and ultimately ended a 424-megawatt cascade through sustained mobilisation. **Permits are often the weak point** — Namakhvani's permit was granted without the required studies, and civil society sued on exactly that ground. **The state decides early** — land was transferred before the permits, so watch the selection-and-land stage, not just the formal review. **Winning can cost** — the state later faced a large arbitration award, a warning about investor-state deals. **And civic space can narrow** — the movement was later smeared and a "foreign agents" law pursued, so protect your people and your legitimacy. The through-line: **build a broad, durable public, challenge the permit and assert your Aarhus rights, document the deal, draw international eyes — and, above all, sustain the movement, because in Georgia the public is what wins.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you gather a neighbour or write a word, you must know exactly what you are facing, who decides, where the chain is weakest, and how far the state has already committed. Acting before you know these things wastes effort. Spend your first days answering five questions.

The Five Questions

1. What exactly is the project, and where is it in the process? A hydropower cascade, a mine, a quarry, a resort, a road — and has the state selected a developer, transferred land, signed an agreement? Is the environmental permit issued or pending? Has "preparatory" work begun? The Namakhvani lesson is that the real decision may come early, at the selection-and-land stage, long before the formal permit — so map where the project truly stands, not just where the paperwork says.

2. What does it threaten, and what has the state given away? The valley, river, forest, or coast at stake — and, crucially, the terms: how much state land was transferred, on what lease, at what price; whether the agreement is confidential; whether the state guaranteed to buy the output. These terms are both the harm and, often, the vulnerability

— the Rioni movement made the giveaway of land and the one-sided contract central to its case.

3. Is the environmental permit complete and lawful? This is often the strongest legal question. Was a full EIA done for the whole project? Was the public genuinely consulted? Namakhvani's permit was granted without the required studies and without assessing the upper cascade — a clear flaw. If the permit rests on an incomplete or unlawful assessment, you have a real legal ground.

4. Who decides, who benefits, and is the community mobilisable? Which ministry or fund drove it? Which foreign investor benefits? And — decisively in Georgia — is there a community with the cohesion and will to mobilise and sustain itself, as the Rioni Valley did? Your honest read of the community's capacity shapes the whole strategy.

5. What is the civic climate and the risk? Georgia is a hybrid democracy: protest is possible and has won, but flashpoints have seen police dispersal and blockades, and the ruling party has smeared environmental movements as foreign agents. Judge the climate honestly, plan lawful and disciplined action, arrange legal support, and protect your people's legitimacy against the "foreign agent" narrative.

Reading the Answers

Work the five questions together and a picture forms. **A project with an incomplete or unlawful permit, threatening a valued place, in a community able to mobilise** points toward the strongest Georgian configuration: a permit challenge and Aarhus claims, carried on the shoulders of a broad, sustained public — the Rioni formula. **A project the state has already decided, with land transferred and civic space tight**, points toward mobilisation, documentation of the giveaway, the Aarhus mechanisms, and international attention, with realistic expectations. **In every case**, the public is your strongest lever, and the terms of the deal and the defects of the permit are your sharpest evidence.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Before going further, decide with a small, trusted group what winning would mean — concretely and honestly. Depending on your situation, a realistic goal might be: an environmental permit annulled or reopened; a project suspended, withdrawn, or shelved under sustained public pressure, as Namakhvani was; the Aarhus rights enforced and the process reopened; the deal's terms exposed and renegotiated; or delay and international scrutiny that make a project untenable. Rioni shows that stopping is genuinely possible in Georgia — but it also shows that winning can carry costs, including the arbitration risk, that a movement should anticipate. A goal that fits your community's capacity and your honest read of the state's commitment is the responsible one.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything that follows. In Georgia — where courts, the Public Defender, the Aarhus bodies, the press, and above all the public act on evidence — the campaign is strengthened enormously when you can show, in dated, sourced, organised form, exactly what is happening, what the state gave away, what rule was broken, and what harm it does. A community that can prove an incomplete permit, a confidential giveaway of land, or a defective assessment holds the instrument that moves overseers and rallies a public. A community with only anger has far less.

The Mindset: Build a Record for a Court, an Overseer, and the Public

Approach documentation as if you are assembling a file that an administrative-court judge, the Public Defender, an Aarhus case-handler, and — crucially — the public and the press will read: people who act on concrete, provable facts. Everything must be dated, attributed to a source, and stored securely in more than one place, including with trusted allies and outside the country where sensible. Frame it around the rules from Section 2: the Environmental Assessment Code, the Aarhus rights, and the transparency of the deal. In Georgia, evidence of the giveaway — the transferred land, the confidential terms, the state purchase guarantee — is as powerful with the public as evidence of ecological harm, because it speaks to fairness and sovereignty.

What to Document

The project and its permits. What is proposed, by whom, and exactly where it stands — the developer selection, the land transfer, the agreement, the EIA, the environmental permit, the construction permit. Obtain the documents; the gaps — an incomplete EIA, an unassessed part of the project, a confidential clause — are often your case.

The deal and the giveaway. How much state land was transferred, on what lease and at what price; whether the

agreement is confidential; whether the state guaranteed to buy the output. This is distinctively powerful in Georgia, where the Rioni movement made the one-sided terms central.

The environmental and social harm. The valley, river, or forest at stake; the flooding, displacement, and loss; the seismic and safety concerns; the effects on farming and livelihoods — captured with dates, locations, and imagery.

The process. Whether the EIA was complete and lawful, whether the public was genuinely consulted, whether preparatory works began before the proper permit. Procedural and completeness defects are among the most reliable legal grounds.

The policing and the pressure. Any dispersal of protest, blockade of the area, or smearing of the movement — documented for the Public Defender, the press, and international bodies.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Record dates and sources for everything; prefer official documents, imagery, and verifiable data over rumour; and be accurate and restrained, because a file that overstates can be dismissed. Use satellite and remote imagery to document construction and land change without confrontation. **On safety: Georgia is a hybrid democracy — protest and documentation are generally possible and have won, but flashpoints have seen police dispersal and blockades, and the civic climate has tightened, so act lawfully and collectively, arrange legal support in advance, keep copies of everything in more than one place, and guard your movement's legitimacy against the "foreign agent" narrative by keeping your work transparent and locally rooted.** Partner early with Georgia's environmental legal groups and NGOs — Green Alternative, the Social Justice Center, the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, CENN — and international partners such as CEE Bankwatch, who bring the legal framing, the investigative capacity, and the channels to the courts, the Aarhus bodies, and the international press.

Reading a Georgian Permit for Its Weak Points

When you obtain the environmental permit and its assessment, read them like an opponent looking for the seams, because in Georgia the permit is frequently where the project is legally weakest — often precisely because the real decision was made elsewhere, earlier. A few defects recur, and the Namakhvani record shows each. **Completeness** is the first thing to test: was a full environmental-impact assessment carried out for the *whole* project, or — as at Namakhvani, where the upper cascade was never assessed — only for part of it? An incomplete assessment can undermine the entire permit. **The required studies** are the second: were the seismic, hydrological, and safety studies that a project of this scale demands actually done, or was the permit granted despite their absence? **The sequence** is the third, and distinctively Georgian: was state land transferred and the deal signed *before* the permit, so that the assessment was a formality codifying a decision already made? That sequence is itself evidence that the process was not genuine. **Public participation** is the fourth: was the consultation real and timely, or a box-ticking exercise? And **the works** are the fifth: did "preparatory" construction — drilling, blasting, riverbed alteration — begin before the proper permit was settled? Each defect is at once an objection, a ground for a court challenge, and an Aarhus claim — and, told plainly, a story that shows the public the process was rigged.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section turns documentation into a concrete list of sources. Much of Georgia's project record is obtainable, and the Aarhus rights, a working press, and a determined civil society make it reachable. Work through these carefully.

The Official and Legal Record

The environmental-assessment file. The EIA, the scoping documents, the public-consultation record, and the environmental permit are held by the Ministry of Environmental Protection and Agriculture; request the full file. The completeness defects — an unassessed part of the project, missing studies — are frequently the case.

The permits and the agreement. The construction permit, the land-transfer decisions, and the investment agreement (or its non-confidential portions). Request them; a confidential agreement is itself a vulnerability you can expose and challenge.

Property and company records. The National Agency of Public Registry shows land ownership and transfers and company details; cross-border tools (OpenCorporates) trace the foreign investor's structure and links.

Aarhus information requests. Under the Aarhus Convention, you can compel disclosure of environmental information —

studies, permits, monitoring data, correspondence — and a refusal is itself a violation you can take to the Aarhus Compliance Committee.

The Environmental and Safety Sources

Ecological, hydrological, and seismic data. The river and valley's value, the flooding and diversion impacts, and — as at Namakhvani — the seismic and dam-safety concerns that independent experts raised. Independent expert review is powerful here.

Satellite and monitoring data. Global Forest Watch and satellite imagery document construction, blasting, and land change over time, safely and verifiably.

The Oversight and International Record

Public Defender materials. The Public Defender's statements and findings on the conflict — including on any disproportionate policing.

International and financier records. The involvement of international financiers, development banks, or export-credit agencies, whose environmental and social standards a project may breach — a lever with foreign investors.

The Organisations and Channels That Carry the Case

- **Georgian environmental legal groups and NGOs** — Green Alternative, the Social Justice Center, the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, CENN, Caucasian House — who litigate, document, and organise.
- **International partners** — CEE Bankwatch and others — who bring EU-standards expertise, financier leverage, and international attention.
- **The Aarhus mechanisms and the Public Defender**, reachable directly.
- **Investigative journalists**, Georgian and international, who have made these fights visible.

Turning Sources into a Case

As you gather, sort everything against the chain from Section 2 — the selection and land transfer, the deal, the EIA, the permit, the works, the harm — so each piece attaches to the point it proves, and note the confidential terms and the completeness defects especially. By the end you should be able to show, with dated and sourced evidence, what is happening, what the state gave away, what rule was broken, and at what cost — the record that moves the courts, the overseers, and the international press, and that, above all, gives a mobilised public the facts it needs to win.

Researchers for Hire, and Everyday Research Tools

If digging through corporate filings, land records and permit files is beyond a few volunteers, you can hire it out — and this lifts a real weight off novice activists. The field is **opposition research** (or, on the labour side, **corporate-campaign research** — the same methods unions use to expose an employer's finances and record, turned on a developer). For your side, seek **opposition-research firms**, **licensed private investigators** with paid records access, **investigative journalists and freelancers** (often the cheapest, and they publish what they find), **environmental-compliance auditors** to dissect a developer's regulatory record, and **public-records specialists** to pry files loose. The investigative tools they use — and that a determined activist can use directly — include **OpenCorporates** and **OCCRP Aleph** (company ownership and cross-border links, worldwide) and **DocumentCloud** (search and OCR large document dumps), with **SEC EDGAR**, **LittleSis** and **MuckRock** as United States examples; Georgia has its own public registry of property and companies that serves the same purpose, and OCCRP itself has deep roots in the region.

For everyday, subject-agnostic research, a small kit goes far: **AI assistants** — Claude.ai, ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and Perplexity for sourced answers — are excellent for explaining a law, summarising a document, or drafting, so long as you **always verify** what they tell you, because they can invent citations; **Google Scholar** and Google's advanced search operators for studies and buried files; and the **Wayback Machine** for pages a developer or agency has quietly deleted.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documentation gives you a case; organisation gives it power — and in Georgia, more than almost anywhere in this guide, the organised public is the decisive lever. The Rioni Valley did not win in a courtroom; it won because a community would not go home, and a nation stood with it. This section is about building that kind of movement: broad, durable, locally

rooted, disciplined, and resilient against pressure.

Start With a Small, Trusted Core

Begin with a handful of committed people who share the load and can act without drama. Agree early on what you are trying to achieve, who does what, and — given the uneven courts and the civic pressure — who handles the legal work and who protects the movement's legitimacy. In the Rioni, a few local residents began what became a national movement; a small, trusted, determined core is how it starts.

Widen Into a Broad, National Coalition

Georgia's great victory came because a local fight became a national cause. Aim for the same shape. **Local residents** are the moral heart, as the "Guardians of Rioni" were — their refusal to leave was the movement's spine. **Environmental NGOs and legal groups** — Green Alternative, the Social Justice Center, the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, CENN — bring the documentation, the litigation, and the Aarhus expertise. **Students, artists, and citizens from across the country** turned the Rioni into a national movement; reach them. **International partners** bring standards expertise and outside attention. **Sympathetic media and public figures** carry it to the country. Breadth and national reach are what turned a valley's protest into a force the government could not simply police away.

The Distinctive Georgian Lever — Sustained, Rooted Mobilisation

Georgia's decisive lever is a mobilised, rooted public that will not yield. The Rioni Guardians camped in tents for months — a collective 166 nights outside — and drew tens of thousands to Kutaisi and Tbilisi. Sustained, disciplined, visible presence is what wore down a project the government had called essential. So build for endurance and rootedness: the movement's power came from the local community's refusal to leave, amplified by national solidarity. Pair the public pressure with the legal and Aarhus levers, which give it structure and a paper trail — but understand that in Georgia the public presence is often the thing that actually stops the machinery.

Choose Tactics That Fit — and Protect the Movement

Georgia's repertoire is real: public participation, petitions, sustained protest and encampment, coalition-building, litigation, the Aarhus mechanisms, the Public Defender, media, and international outreach, used together. Keep it lawful and disciplined — flashpoints have seen police dispersal and blockades, so plan for that, arrange legal support, and never let a provocation turn a peaceful movement violent. Protect the movement's legitimacy above all: the ruling party has cast environmental protesters as foreign agents or foreign-funded destabilisers, so keep your work transparent, locally rooted, and visibly Georgian, and answer the smear with the plain truth of who you are and what you are defending. Guard against burnout over a long encampment by sharing shifts and the load, renewing the movement, and celebrating milestones. In Georgia, a broad, rooted, disciplined, and resilient public is what has won — build it to last, and protect it.

Hiring Help to Run the Campaign

You need not carry the whole campaign yourselves. A whole industry runs opposition campaigns for hire — the visible turnout at hearings, the public comment, the messaging and the media — known as **grassroots-for-hire** or **public-affairs / grassroots-advocacy** consulting. It usually serves whoever pays, most often the deep-pocketed side, but you can hire the same muscle for yours: **public-interest communications and PR firms, campaign and field-organising firms** that run turnout and canvassing, and, if the fight becomes a public vote, **ballot-measure consultants**. People outside that niche can carry a piece too — a **PR or crisis-communications firm**, a **campaign consultant**, a **digital-advocacy shop**, or a seasoned **community organiser** — taking weight off exhausted volunteers who feel they are carrying the opposition alone. Two rules hold. Hire them **transparently**, and never let anyone fake a grassroots front: that is *astroturfing* — dishonest, and ruinous if exposed; the aim is to amplify a real community, not fabricate one. And mind your **setting** — where the state is quick to brand a movement as foreign-funded or hostile, foreign or paid help handled carelessly can be turned against you, so keep the effort visibly local and Georgian, favour trusted domestic allies, and never let paid help expose your people or your legitimacy.

Sustaining a Long Presence — Lessons From the Guardians

If your fight, like the Rioni, comes to rest on a sustained physical presence — an encampment, a permanent watch, a refusal to leave the site — then endurance becomes a discipline of its own, and it is worth planning for deliberately. The Guardians of Rioni held their ground for a collective 166 nights, through winter, taking shifts in tents. That kind of staying power does not happen by accident; it is organised. A few lessons carry across such campaigns. **Rotate the load**. No one

can camp indefinitely; build a roster so that people cycle through the site and no single family carries it, and so the presence never lapses. **Bring the country to the valley.** The Rioni's endurance was sustained by national solidarity — visitors, supplies, students, citizens who came to stand a shift — so make it easy for supporters from across the country to join, contribute, and witness. **Meet basic needs.** Food, shelter, warmth, sanitation, and safety over months are logistical problems that must be solved for morale to hold; organise them like the sustained operation they are. **Keep it disciplined and lawful.** A long presence is vulnerable to provocation and to the charge of disorder, so agree clear rules, train people for calm in the face of police pressure, and have legal observers and support ready for the flashpoints that will come. **Protect against burnout and despair.** A months-long vigil is exhausting; share leadership, mark milestones, rotate people out to rest, and keep the wider legal and media work visibly moving so the encampment never feels like the only front. And **keep the presence connected to the paper trail** — the permit challenge, the Aarhus claims, the documentation — so that the people holding the valley know their stand is structured and legitimised by a legal case, not standing alone. The physical presence is often what actually stops the machinery in Georgia; sustaining it is the campaign's hardest and most important logistical task.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal action in Georgia is a genuine lever, though a less certain one than in a full democracy, and it works best woven together with the public pressure that is your strongest card. Its two most useful strands are the challenge to a defective permit and the assertion of your Aarhus rights. This section explains the openings. It is not a substitute for a lawyer, and finding one experienced in environmental and administrative law — through Georgia's environmental legal groups — is an early and vital task.

The Core Openings

Challenging the environmental permit. The central legal route: a court challenge to the environmental permit on the ground that it was issued without a complete or lawful EIA, without genuine public consultation, or in breach of the Environmental Assessment Code. This is exactly what civil society did over Namakhvani, where the permit was granted without the required studies and the upper cascade was never assessed. A permit resting on an incomplete assessment is your firmest legal ground.

Challenging the construction permit and the works. Where preparatory or construction works began without a proper permit or in breach of conditions — as protesters alleged at Namakhvani — that is a further challenge and a basis to seek suspension of the works.

Asserting your Aarhus rights. The Aarhus Convention gives you rights to environmental information, to participation, and to access to justice. Where information is withheld, participation denied, or justice obstructed, you can assert those rights domestically and, ultimately, before the **Aarhus Convention Compliance Committee** — an international body that has found Georgia in breach before and whose findings carry weight.

Exposing the confidential agreement. A confidential investment agreement, especially one transferring public land and guaranteeing to buy the output, is both a political and a legal vulnerability — challenge the secrecy and the terms.

The Oversight Routes

The Public Defender. Refer rights violations — disproportionate policing, denial of participation, the blockade of a protest — to the Public Defender, whose findings, though non-binding, carry moral and political weight and protect the movement.

International financiers and standards. Where a development bank, an export-credit agency, or an international financier is involved, its environmental and social standards and its accountability mechanisms are a real lever — a documented breach can move the money behind a project.

Standing, the Courts, and Realistic Expectations

Three points. First, **standing**: affected residents and environmental organisations can bring administrative challenges, so let an experienced legal group carry the case. Second, **the courts are uneven** — their independence is contested and outcomes less certain than in a full democracy, so treat litigation as one strand among several, valuable for the delay, the record, and the legitimacy it creates, and never as the whole strategy. Third, **be realistic and weigh the arbitration risk**: stopping a foreign-investor project can trigger an international arbitration claim against the state, as Namakhvani did, and the government will use that risk to argue against you — so understand it, and let the case for stopping rest on

the project's genuine illegality and harm.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Be clear-eyed. Litigation can annul or reopen a defective permit, suspend unlawful works, and create delay and a public record; the Aarhus mechanisms can enforce your rights and reopen a process; the Public Defender and the international standards reach the officials and the financiers. But in Georgia, legal action is most powerful as the structured companion to a mobilised public — the paper trail and the legitimacy beneath a movement that is doing the decisive work in the street and the valley. Treat the permit challenge and the Aarhus claims as your legal spine, run them alongside the public pressure, and remember that the Rioni was won not in a courtroom but by a community that would not yield — with the law documenting, legitimising, and reinforcing what the people were achieving.

The Rioni Precedent — How People Power Won

The single most important case for a Georgian community to know is the Rioni Valley fight, because it shows exactly how a community wins in Georgia when the institutions are uneven. The Namakhvani cascade — a 424-megawatt hydropower scheme on the Rioni River, developed by a Turkish-led consortium — was treated by the government as a strategic priority for energy independence. Hundreds of hectares of state land were transferred to the company before the permits, a confidential agreement was signed, and the state guaranteed to buy the plant's electricity for years. On paper, the project looked unstoppable. And it was stopped — not by a court, but by a community. When preparatory works began in 2020, a handful of local residents started a protest to save their valley. It grew. The "Guardians of Rioni" camped in tents through the winter, taking shifts, spending a collective 166 nights outside. Civil-society groups sued to annul the permit, which had been granted without the required studies. National solidarity swelled: tens of thousands marched in Kutaisi and Tbilisi. The state answered with police dispersal and a blockade of the valley, which the Public Defender condemned as disproportionate — and still the Guardians did not leave. In mid-2021 the government said the project would not continue in its current form, and the developer withdrew. When you build your campaign, build it as the Rioni movement did: rooted in a determined local community, widened into a national cause, structured by a legal challenge to a defective permit, and sustained past the point where the state expected it to break. It is the proven Georgian route, and it stopped a project the government wanted built.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, the Public Defender, a journalist, a politician, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each is what lets a community reach every lever at once — and, in Georgia, mobilise the public that matters most.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that hundreds of hectares of state land were transferred to the developer before any permit was issued, under a confidential agreement. That one fact becomes:

- **A legal argument:** the permit that followed was a formality following a decision already made, and the process breached the law's requirement of a genuine assessment.
- **An Aarhus argument:** the secrecy of the agreement and the exclusion of the public breach the rights to information and participation.
- **A political argument:** the state gave away public land and guaranteed to buy the output, at the public's expense and to a foreign investor's benefit.
- **A public and national argument:** the government handed a Georgian valley and river to outsiders on secret terms, without asking the people who live there — an argument of fairness and sovereignty that moves the whole country.
- **A media argument:** a documented giveaway, a secret deal, a valley sold off — a story that carries.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Georgia the fairness-and-sovereignty argument is often the one that builds the public.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The court wants the breach framed against the specific requirement — the incomplete EIA, the unlawful permit, the works begun without proper authority — with the documents that prove it.

The Public Defender and the Aarhus bodies want the rights violation — the secrecy, the denied participation, the disproportionate policing — clearly evidenced.

Journalists and the public want the human and national story made vivid and true — the valley, the river, the families, the secret deal, the community that would not yield.

Politicians and international partners want the accountability and reputational angle — the giveaway, the arbitration risk of a bad deal, the breach of financier standards.

The Master Frame: "Our Valley, Given Away in Secret — and We Would Not Let It Go"

Across every audience, the strongest frame in Georgia joins the illegality to the fairness and the defiance: this project rests on a defective permit and a secret giveaway of Georgian land, water, and money; the law and the Aarhus rights were broken; and — as the Rioni proved — a rooted, determined community can refuse to yield and win. Framing the fight this way is accurate; it is legally grounded, engaging the courts and the Aarhus bodies; and it carries the moral and national force that, in Georgia, builds the public that wins. Insisting — with evidence — that a Georgian place was given away unlawfully and in secret, and that its people will defend it, is your strongest argument.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media turns a local objection into a national cause — and in Georgia, national attention is often the thing that turns a valley's protest into a movement the government cannot ignore. The Rioni became a national story, and that was central to its power. Use media deliberately, in service of your goal, alongside the legal and organising work beneath it.

What Coverage Achieves

Coverage turns a local fight into a national one; it pressures officials who dislike scrutiny; it reaches allies, lawyers, students, and citizens across the country; it exposes the secret deal and the giveaway; it draws international eyes and reaches foreign investors and financiers; and it protects a movement against smears by putting the truth of who you are before the public. The Rioni movement's national visibility was part of what forced the project's suspension.

Build the Story Around People, Place, and the Deal

The most powerful Georgian stories combine a human and national face with a documented fact: a family and a valley against a foreign developer; a river given away in secret; farmers and their land against a dam. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof — the incomplete permit, the transferred land, the confidential terms; keep it accurate. Prepare a few clear, repeatable messages — what the project is, what it would destroy, what was given away, what you are asking — and keep every spokesperson on them, drawn visibly from the local community.

Reach Every Layer

Local and regional media reach the affected community. **National outlets** carry the fight to the country — the decisive layer in Georgia, where national solidarity is what wins. **International media** matter where a foreign investor, a financier, or a European partner is involved — coverage abroad reaches the money and the standards. **Social media and your own channels** mobilise quickly and directly, and were central to the Rioni movement — strongest when anchored to verified facts and rooted visibly in the community.

Discipline and Safety

Be accurate always; one exaggeration handed to the other side can discredit a campaign, so verify before you publish and correct fast. Stay on message. Anticipate the counter-narratives — that opponents are against energy independence, or are foreign-funded agents destabilising the country — and pre-empt them by grounding everything in the law, the deal, the valley, and the plainly local and Georgian identity of the movement. Protect the people who speak, especially at flashpoints where protest has been policed, and never let a photo opportunity pull participants into a confrontation whose risk they did not choose. Used with discipline, media — and above all national attention — is the amplifier that, in Georgia, has turned a valley into a movement and a movement into a victory.

Amplifying at Scale — Media Help for Hire

Beyond pitching reporters yourselves, you can pay to spread the story at scale — different from a single advert or one call to a local outlet, and available at any reach from local to global. **Public-relations and communications firms** run earned-media campaigns — placing op-eds, orchestrating coverage, staging the media push; for the cause side, public-interest firms such as Fenton, BerlinRosen and M+R work for advocacy groups and unions, not only corporations. **Press-release / newswire distribution services** send a release across a wide network of journalists and outlets — PR Newswire, Business Wire and GlobeNewswire at the global, higher-budget end; EIN Presswire, PRWeb and eReleases far cheaper and nonprofit-friendly, some with cause-specific wires. And **digital and social amplification** shops run targeted paid campaigns and creator partnerships. Two rules: amplify a *true* story from a *real* community — never manufacture fake outrage; and in Georgia, keep the amplification visibly rooted in the local community, because a movement that looks foreign-run is easily smeared, while a valley speaking for itself is what moved the country.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you enter objections, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, in more than one place. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence.

8A. Objection During the Environmental Consultation

To: the Ministry of Environmental Protection and Agriculture **Subject:** Objection — [project], environmental permit procedure [ref]

As a person affected by [project] at [location], I object during the public-consultation stage. My grounds, with evidence: (1) the environmental-impact assessment is incomplete — [it omits / it does not assess (part of the project)]; (2) [the required studies] were not carried out; (3) the consultation [was inadequate]. I request that the environmental permit be REFUSED, or that a complete and lawful assessment be required first, and that this objection be entered on the record. [Attachments.]

8B. Aarhus Information Request

To: [the Ministry / the competent authority] **Subject:** Request for environmental information (Aarhus Convention) — [project]

Under the Aarhus Convention and Georgian law, please provide: the environmental-impact assessment and scoping documents; the environmental and construction permits and their conditions; the land-transfer decisions and the investment agreement; the monitoring data; and the correspondence between [the authority] and [the developer]. Please respond within the legal period. A refusal to disclose environmental information is itself a breach I may pursue, including before the Aarhus Compliance Committee.

8C. Court Challenge to the Permit (via counsel)

To: the [administrative court], via counsel **Subject:** Challenge to [the environmental permit / the construction permit] — [project]

As [affected residents / an environmental organisation with standing], we challenge [the permit], issued on [date], on the grounds that [the EIA was incomplete and did not assess (part of the project) / the permit was issued without the required studies / genuine public consultation was denied / works began without proper authority]. We request suspension of [the permit / the works] pending judgment. [Grounds and evidence attached.]

8D. Referral to the Public Defender

To: the Public Defender of Georgia **Subject:** Referral — [rights violation] in connection with [project], [location]

We bring to your attention [the denial of public participation / the disproportionate policing and blockade of protest / the withholding of environmental information] in connection with [project]. The facts, with evidence: [documented account]. We request that you examine the matter and issue findings, and we attach the documentation.

8E. Letter to the Ministry or Government

To: [the Ministry / the relevant government body] **Subject:** [Refuse / suspend / reconsider] [project] [ref]

We are residents of [place] writing about [project]. Our concern, briefly: [one or two specific grounds — an incomplete permit, a secret giveaway of land, a threat to the valley]. We ask you to [specific, achievable action]. [If true:] [#] residents and [#] organisations share this concern; the process carries legal risk and public opposition. We welcome a meeting and can share our full evidence.

8F. Complaint to an International Financier or Standards Body

To: [the development bank / export-credit agency / financier] **Subject:** Concern — [project] and your environmental and social standards

We write regarding [project] in [location], [financed / supported] by your institution. We believe the project breaches your environmental and social standards in that [documented breach — an incomplete assessment, denied participation, a secret agreement, harm to a protected valley]. We request that you review the project against your standards and your accountability mechanism, and we attach the evidence.

8G. Coalition Outreach Email (to an environmental NGO)

To: [Green Alternative / the Social Justice Center / the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association / CENN] **Subject:** [Project] — would you support or bring a challenge?

We are a community group in [place] working on [project], which [one-line stake — e.g. "would flood our valley on a permit granted without the required studies"]. We are getting in touch because your organisation has the legal experience, the Aarhus expertise, and the standing to challenge such permits. We are not asking you to adopt our whole campaign — just to consider [advising on the strongest grounds / bringing a permit challenge / an Aarhus claim]. We have documented evidence and community support and can share a brief and arrange a call.

8H. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [place]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something in [place] your readers should know, with a clear news hook: [documents] show [quantified finding — e.g. "hundreds of hectares of state land were transferred before any permit, under a confidential deal"], and [the community is resisting / a decision is due] [date]. It's new, specific, and rooted in a local community. I can share the full file and connect you with residents and [an expert]. Could we talk this week?

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence; attach your documentation; and route them, where you can, through or with an experienced environmental NGO that can strengthen the framing and carry the court and Aarhus work. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Georgia that record documents, legitimises, and reinforces the public pressure that is doing the decisive work.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With an afternoon a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

1. Find out where the project really stands — today. Has the state selected a developer, transferred land, signed a deal? Is the permit issued or pending? Have works begun? The Namakhvani lesson is that the real decision comes early — so learn the true stage, not just the paperwork.

2. Request the file under Aarhus. One information request (8B) forces out the EIA, the permits, the land transfers, and the agreement — often revealing the incomplete assessment or the secret giveaway that becomes your case.

3. Object during the environmental consultation. One clear objection (8A) naming the completeness defect and the denied participation puts your case on the record and preserves your position.

4. Sound the alarm and start building the public. In Georgia the public is the decisive lever, so tell your neighbours, tell the country, and begin — even in a small way — the visible, local presence that in the Rioni grew into a national movement.

5. Hand the legal fight to an environmental NGO. Green Alternative, the Social Justice Center, the Georgian Young Lawyers' Association, and CENN have the lawyers and the Aarhus expertise — point them at your project (8G) and they may carry the challenge.

6. Tell one reporter. National attention is what wins in Georgia; a single accurate tip (8H), rooted in the local community, can turn a valley's fight into a national one.

7. Refer any policing or secrecy to the Public Defender. If protest is dispersed or information withheld, a referral (8D) puts an independent overseer on the record.

Do only the first four and you will have learned the true stage, forced out the file, put your objection on the record, and begun to build the public that, in Georgia, is what stops a project. Then come back and read the rest.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Georgia's system is tilted in ways you must understand precisely, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that still work — above all the public.

Where the Tilt Shows

The government drives "strategic" projects and frames them as energy independence; it has selected developers, transferred state land, and signed confidential agreements before the formal permits, turning permitting into a codification of a decision already made. The courts' independence is contested. And — the sharpest recent turn — civic space has narrowed: after the Rioni victory, the ruling party smeared the movement as foreign-funded and Russia-linked, and pursued a "foreign agents" law casting NGOs and protesters as hostile actors. Where the tilt is this deep, the formal process alone cannot be relied on — but powerful levers still reach past it.

What Still Works — And One Is Very Strong

The decisive point about Georgia is that even where the system tilts, one lever above all has proven it can win, and others reach past the tilt.

The mobilised public is the strongest lever, and it has won outright. The Rioni Valley stopped a project the government called essential — not through the courts, but through a rooted, sustained, national movement the state could not police away. Where a community can mobilise and endure, this is your firmest ground.

The Aarhus mechanisms reach past domestic tilt. The rights to information, participation, and justice are backed by an international Compliance Committee that has found Georgia in breach before — a lever a captured domestic process cannot neutralise.

International attention and financier standards reach the money. Foreign investors, development banks, and European partners are sensitive to reputation and to breaches of standards — and to Georgia's European aspirations.

The Public Defender checks the officials. Its findings, though non-binding, carry weight and protect the movement.

The deal's secrecy and unfairness are a vulnerability. The confidential terms and the giveaway of public land are political dynamite with a public that responds to fairness and sovereignty.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Georgia is real but demanding. Where a community can mobilise and sustain itself, the public is a lever that has stopped a major project outright, reinforced by the Aarhus mechanisms, international attention, and the exposure of a secret, one-sided deal — the Rioni proof. Where the state has already decided, the courts are uncertain, and civic space is under pressure, the fight is harder and the institutional levers weaker, and you must protect your movement's legitimacy against the "foreign agent" smear and weigh the arbitration risk honestly. But even then the public, the Aarhus rights, and international scrutiny carry real weight. Diagnose the tilt honestly, build and protect the public that is your strongest card, assert your international rights, and expose the deal.

The Arbitration Trap — Understand It, Don't Fear It

One feature of Georgian fights deserves its own strategy, because the government will use it against you: the risk of international investor-state arbitration. Many large projects rest on agreements with foreign investors that include protections enforceable through international arbitration. When Georgia's government unilaterally stepped back from the Namakhvani contract after the protests, the developer took the state to arbitration and won, leaving Georgia facing a compensation award of hundreds of millions of dollars. The government now points to that cost to argue that resisting such projects is irresponsible and expensive for every citizen. You need to understand this trap and plan around it, because it is real. Three points help. First, **the arbitration risk is largely a consequence of how the state ends a project, not of the community's opposition** — an award follows a unilateral state breach of a confidential deal, so the safest ground is to force the project's end through its own genuine illegality (an unlawful permit, a breached assessment, a rights violation), which is far harder to characterise as an arbitrary state breach. Second, **the terms that create the arbitration exposure are the same terms that outrage the public** — the secret agreement, the state guarantee to buy the output, the giveaway of land — so exposing them serves both the political fight and the argument that the deal was flawed from the start. Third, **the answer to "resisting costs money" is that the deal itself was the costly mistake** — a confidential, one-sided agreement that locked the public into paying, whichever way it ended. Do not let the arbitration threat silence you; understand it, aim your fight at the project's real illegality, and turn the bad deal into the argument.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Most bad decisions are lawful decisions you disagree with. But genuine corruption and capture exist in Georgia — in the awarding of strategic projects, the transfer of state land, the negotiation of confidential deals, and the pressuring of process — and recognising it tells you which lever works and which is closed. Handle it carefully: allege only what your evidence supports.

Signs of Capture

Watch for the patterns: a developer selected by a commercial entity rather than through open, accountable process; state land transferred to a company before any permit; a confidential agreement guaranteeing the investor's returns at the public's expense; permits issued as a formality after the decision was already made; inspections that find no fault despite evident breaches; and, at the political level, a state so committed to a project that it smears and legislates against those who oppose it. The Namakhvani record showed several of these — land transferred before permits, a confidential deal, a state purchase guarantee, inspections that overlooked breaches.

Why This Changes Your Strategy

Where capture protects the harm, persuading the captured body is futile. The strategy shifts to the levers that reach past the capture — and, in Georgia, to the public:

- **The mobilised public.** A rooted, national movement is the lever a captured state cannot easily deflect, as the Rioni proved.
- **The Aarhus mechanisms and international bodies.** An international Compliance Committee and foreign financiers' standards reach past domestic capture.
- **International attention.** Exposure of a corrupt or captured deal, especially to European partners and investors, raises the cost.
- **The Public Defender and any independent oversight,** for the rights violations that capture produces.

Document It Carefully and Safely

If you are documenting corruption or capture, do so with rigour and restraint. Distinguish always between what you can prove and what you suspect; allege only what your evidence supports; and refer serious allegations through lawyers and the proper channels, not through reckless public accusation, which can expose you and hand your opponents the story — especially in a climate where the state is eager to portray the movement as hostile. Keep your documentation secure and in more than one place. In Georgia, the exposure of a captured, secret, one-sided deal — carried to the public, the international bodies, and the press — is both powerful and popular, because it speaks to fairness and sovereignty; but doing it carefully, transparently, and from a visibly local and Georgian foundation is how a community both wins and

protects itself.

When Civic Space Narrows — Protecting the Movement

A hard reality of organising in Georgia today is that the civic space has tightened, and a campaign must plan for it from the start. After the Rioni victory, the ruling party cast the movement as foreign-funded and Russia-linked, and pursued a "foreign agents" law framing NGOs and activists as hostile actors serving outside interests. This is a deliberate strategy: to delegitimise a movement rather than answer it, and to make ordinary citizens wary of joining. Protecting your movement against it is not optional. Keep the campaign **visibly local and Georgian** — let residents of the affected place be its face and its voice, so that the claim of foreign control collapses against the plain fact of a community defending its own valley. Keep the work **transparent** — open about who you are, what you want, and where any support comes from — so there is nothing to "expose." Root the argument in **fairness and sovereignty** — a Georgian place, given away in secret to outsiders — which turns the nationalist framing back against the project rather than the protesters. And **support your people** if they are targeted — legally, publicly, and as a community — so that no one stands alone against the pressure. The Rioni was won in a more open climate than today's; winning now means doing the same work while actively defending the movement's legitimacy and its people against a state that would rather smear the opposition than meet it.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps in this guide are not a menu to pick from; they are strands to weave together over time, with the public at the centre and the law and the Aarhus rights giving it structure. This section shows how they combine, and roughly when each comes into play.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

The power of a Georgian campaign comes from combining its strands around the public. **Documentation** feeds everything — the court challenge, the Aarhus claim, the media, and the public's understanding of the giveaway. **The mobilised public** is the decisive lever, the one that stopped Namakhvani. **The permit challenge and the Aarhus mechanisms** give the movement legal structure, a paper trail, and legitimacy, and can reopen a process. **The Public Defender and international bodies** check the officials and reach the money. **Media and national attention** turn a valley into a movement. Each strand strengthens the others: a documented secret giveaway becomes a court challenge, an Aarhus claim, a national news story, and — above all — the fuel that builds a public determined to defend its valley. No single strand reliably wins on its own in Georgia; woven together around a rooted, sustained public, they won the Rioni.

A Rough Timeline

Early (first weeks). Learn the true stage — selection, land, deal, permit, works. Request the file under Aarhus; object during any consultation. Engage a lawyer or an NGO. And begin, even in a small way, the local, visible presence that can grow into a movement.

Building (weeks to months). File the permit challenge and any Aarhus claim; deepen the documentation, especially of the deal and the completeness defects. Build the coalition wide and national — residents, NGOs, students, citizens — and the media presence, and begin sustained, rooted public mobilisation, protecting its legitimacy against the "foreign agent" narrative.

Sustained (months to years). Keep the public presence, the litigation, the Aarhus claims, the media, and the international outreach alive together, adapting as the situation shifts. Sustain the people through a long encampment or campaign — the Rioni Guardians endured 166 nights — by sharing the load, renewing the movement, and keeping the legal and international work moving.

Throughout. Reassess honestly. If the public grows, press it; if the state grinds on, keep exposing the deal, asserting your international rights, and drawing outside attention, and weigh the arbitration risk in your goals. And keep the public central at every step: in Georgia, a rooted, determined, national movement — documented and legitimised by the law and the Aarhus rights — is the firmest ground a community stands on.

The Two Truths of Rioni

The Rioni carries two lessons, and an honest campaign holds both. **The first is that people power works in Georgia.** A community that would not yield, widened into a national movement and structured by a legal challenge to a defective permit, stopped a strategic dam the government had championed. Where a community can mobilise and endure, this is

the most powerful lever in the country. **The second is that winning is not free, and the ground can shift beneath you.** After the developer pulled out, it took Georgia to international arbitration and won, leaving the state facing a compensation award of hundreds of millions of dollars — a warning that the investor-state agreements underlying these projects can make even a popular victory costly for the public purse, and that the government will wield that risk against future movements. And the ruling party, stung by the defeat, later cast the movement as foreign-funded and Russia-linked and pursued a "foreign agents" law, narrowing the very space that made the Rioni possible. The lesson is not to despair but to plan: build and protect a rooted, visibly Georgian movement; assert your legal and international rights so the win rests on genuine illegality, not on a unilateral state breach that invites arbitration; and go in clear-eyed about both the power you hold and the costs a victory can carry.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Georgia is, for a community facing a destructive project, a country of one remarkable strength and several real limits. Both are true, and which you meet depends above all on whether your community can mobilise.

The strength is genuine and proven. **In Georgia, ordinary people have stopped a major project through sustained mobilisation.** The Rioni Valley movement — a handful of local residents who became a national cause, camping in tents for a collective 166 nights and drawing tens of thousands to the streets — suspended and ultimately ended the 424-megawatt Namakhvani hydropower cascade, a project the government had called essential to the country's energy independence. It was not a court that stopped it; it was a valley that would not yield, and a nation that stood with it. That is the most important fact this guide can give a Georgian community: here, a rooted, determined public can win.

But the limits are real. Georgia's courts are of contested independence; its permitting has at times been a formality following decisions already made, with state land transferred and confidential deals signed before the process ran; and its civic space has narrowed, with the very movement that saved the Rioni later smeared as foreign agents and a "foreign agents" law pursued. And winning can carry a price: after the developer withdrew, it took Georgia to international arbitration and won, leaving the state facing a compensation award of hundreds of millions — a warning about the investor-state deals that underlie many large projects. The tools are real, but the strongest of them is the public, and the institutional levers are weaker and less certain than in a full democracy.

What Distinguishes the Campaigns That Win

The Georgian campaigns that succeed share a pattern. They **build a broad, rooted, national public** and sustain it — the Rioni formula. They **challenge the defective permit and assert their Aarhus rights**, giving the movement legal structure and legitimacy. They **expose the deal** — the giveaway of land, the secret terms — because fairness and sovereignty move the country. They **draw international attention** to reach the investors and the standards. And they **protect their legitimacy** against the smear, keeping the movement transparent and visibly Georgian. The campaigns that come to grief rely on uncertain courts alone, fail to build the public, or let themselves be painted as foreign or hostile.

A Closing Word

If you are reading this because a project threatens your valley, your river, your forest, or your coast, understand that in Georgia you are not without recourse — and that you stand in the country whose Rioni Valley stopped a dam the government wanted, through nothing more than a community that would not go home. The method is clear: learn the true stage of the project; challenge the permit and assert your Aarhus rights; document the deal and the defects; draw national and international attention; and, above all, build a broad, rooted, disciplined public and sustain it, protecting its legitimacy against the smear. It does not promise an easy win, and it asks you to weigh real limits — the uncertain courts, the tightening civic space, the arbitration risk. But it is the method by which the Guardians of Rioni stopped what the government wanted built — and it is the firmest ground a community can stand on. Judge your campaign by real outcomes — a permit annulled or reopened, a project suspended or shelved, a deal exposed, a valley defended — build and protect the public, and hold to the knowledge that here, a rooted and determined people have stopped what the powerful wanted built.

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

"Winning" in Georgia takes several forms, and it is worth naming them so you recognise one when it comes: a **project suspended, withdrawn, or shelved** under sustained public pressure, as Namakhvani was; an **environmental permit**

annulled or reopened by a court for an incomplete or unlawful assessment; the **Aarhus rights enforced** and a closed process reopened; a **secret, one-sided deal exposed** and renegotiated or abandoned; a **Public Defender or international finding** that raises the cost; or a project **delayed and internationally scrutinised** until it becomes untenable. The greatest of these — the shelving of Namakhvani — came through mass, rooted mobilisation, structured by a legal challenge and national attention. Judge your campaign by these outcomes. And be honest about the shadow side the Rioni also revealed: stopping a foreign-investor project can trigger a costly arbitration award against the state, and a victorious movement can afterwards be smeared and legislated against. Anticipate these costs, weigh them in your goals, and protect your movement — but do not let them obscure the central truth that here, a determined public has genuinely won.